ERA 8

Manifest Destiny

1803 – 1860

Manifest Destiny · Texas · Oregon · the far West

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the belief in Manifest Destiny drive American expansion across the continent?

KEY TERMS

Manifest Destiny · Texas Revolution · the Alamo · Oregon Trail · 54°40' · the Gold Rush

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 5.1–5.2 · AMSCO Ch. 5.1–5.2

A CONTINENT FOR THE TAKING

Manifest Destiny

Manifest Destiny



- In 1845 journalist **John O'Sullivan** coined **Manifest Destiny**.
- It held that God intended white Americans to settle the entire continent.
- The idea fused nationalism, faith, and a belief in racial superiority.

Why Americans Went West

LAND

Cheap Land

Vast, fertile territory beckoned farmers and speculators.

→

OPPORTUNITY

A Fresh Start

Economic hardship pushed families to seek new lives.

→

BELIEF

Manifest Destiny

A powerful ideology made expansion feel like destiny.

SECTION

Texas

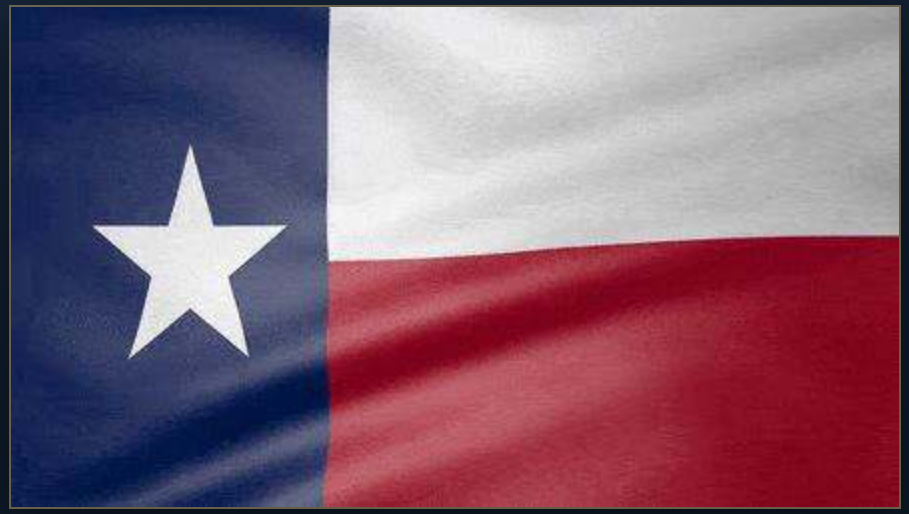
The Texas Revolution



- American settlers in Mexican Texas clashed with **Santa Anna**'s government.
- In 1836, Mexican forces killed the defenders of the **Alamo**.
- 'Remember the **Alamo**!' became a rallying cry for independence.

The Lone Star Republic

- **Sam Houston**'s forces routed **Santa Anna** at **San Jacinto**.
- Texas won independence in 1836 as the **Lone Star Republic**.
- Fears over slavery delayed U.S. **annexation** until 1845.



SECTION

Oregon

Oregon Fever



- Thousands braved the 2,000-mile **Oregon Trail** in the 1840s.
- Expansionists demanded all of Oregon: **'54°40' or Fight!'**
- President **Polk** compromised with Britain at the 49th parallel (1846).

SECTION

The Far West

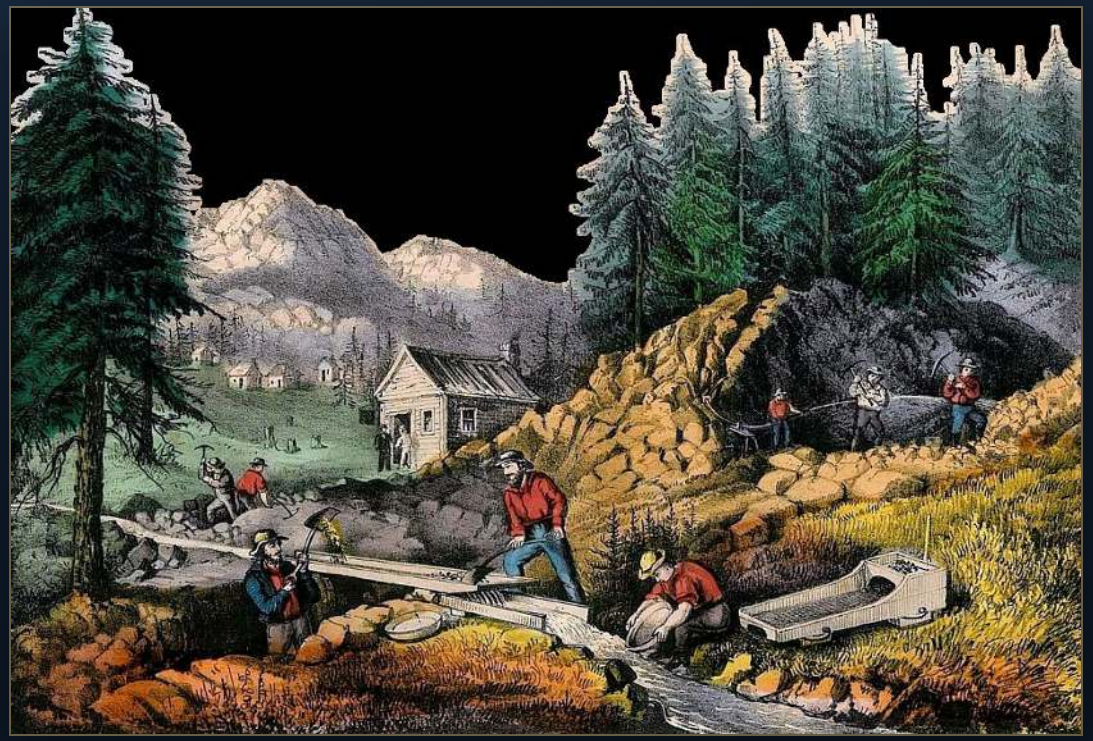
The Mormons Seek Refuge



- **Joseph Smith** founded the Mormon faith—and faced fierce persecution.
- After Smith's murder, **Brigham Young** led followers west in 1847.
- They built a new community by the Great Salt Lake in present-day Utah.

The California Gold Rush

- Gold was discovered in California in 1848, igniting the **Gold Rush**.
- **Forty-niners** poured in from around the world.
- The rush enriched few—and devastated California's Native population.



The Cost of Expansion

MIGRATION

Settlers Pour West

Americans flood Texas, Oregon, and California.

→

DISPLACEMENT

Native Loss

Indigenous and Mexican communities are pushed aside.

→

CONFLICT

War Looms

The drive for land sets the U.S. on a collision course with Mexico.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Manifest Destiny

1. The ideology of **Manifest Destiny** fueled a surge of westward migration in the 1840s.
2. The **Texas Revolution** and the **Oregon** settlement dramatically expanded U.S. claims.
3. The **Gold Rush** and Mormon migration populated the far West—while displacing Native and Mexican peoples and pushing the U.S. toward war with Mexico.

DISCUSS & APPLY

Manifest Destiny

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the ideology of **Manifest Destiny** justified—and accelerated—westward expansion.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

Place the annexation of **Texas** and **Oregon** in the wider context of rising tensions with Mexico and Britain.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did westward expansion change life for **Native peoples and Mexicans** already living in the West?

Up next — **Lesson 19: The Mexican-American War** (war, the Gold Rush & the Wilmot Proviso)